

## LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

## THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

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| ISSUE             | ATB-2026-6                             |
| COVERAGE PERIOD   | 14–19 APR 2026                         |
| PUBLICATION DATE  | 2026-04-19                             |
| DOMINANT JUDGMENT | GEOPOLITICS SHAPING THE THREAT SURFACE |

*Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.*

This issue of the **Alamo Threat Brief** covers the week of **19 April 2026** and assesses a threat environment that cannot be understood without its geopolitical frame. The Iran-U.S. confrontation that began with February's strikes is unresolved. North Korea is operating under tightening sanctions with a strategic requirement to extract revenue by any means available. China is watching a Taiwan Strait environment that grows more consequential by the quarter. Russia's war economy continues to shelter criminal cyber actors targeting Western institutions. This week's developments — North Korea using artificial intelligence to compromise individuals rather than systems, Iran's OT disruption campaign continuing without retreat, and law enforcement disrupting criminal infrastructure that will reconstitute — are **geopolitics expressing itself through technology**. Texas is in the target set for all of it.

**Decision 1 — The Adversary Is Targeting Your People, Not Just Your Systems**

**North Korea confirmed this week that it can make a fraudulent contact indistinguishable from a legitimate one.** If your organization has employees with privileged access to financial systems, cloud infrastructure, or sensitive data, decide whether your session monitoring, access controls, and awareness posture reflect that threat model. The adversary is not at your firewall. They are in your employee's inbox.

**Decision 2 — Iran's OT Campaign Did Not End Last Week**

**The federal advisory confirming Iranian disruption of U.S. industrial systems described an ongoing campaign.** No Texas-named victim appeared in open reporting this week. That is a gap in public disclosure, not evidence the campaign paused. If you operate energy, water, or industrial infrastructure in Texas, decide whether you are treating this as an active condition or a closed news cycle.

**Decision 3 — Your Intelligence Layer May Have a Structural Gap**

**The federal government permanently narrowed its vulnerability intelligence support this week.** If your organization relies on national databases for patch prioritization, that process is now less complete than it was seven days ago. Decide whether you have a supplemental source of threat intelligence, or whether gaps in federal enrichment become gaps in your defenses.

### CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

The central insight of this week's threat picture is strategic, not technical. **The most capable adversaries targeting Texas organizations have concluded that trusted access is cheaper to exploit than defended perimeters.** North Korea does not need to crack your network if it can compromise the person who already has the keys. Iran does not need to defeat your firewall if it can disrupt the industrial system your firewall was never designed to protect. China does not need to announce its presence if it can sit quietly inside your infrastructure until the geopolitical moment that makes that access consequential.

These are not separate campaigns. They are a shared doctrine — one in which the attack surface is not your technology stack but the trusted relationships your organization depends on to function. The people you trust. The platforms your teams communicate through. The enterprise software woven invisibly into your operations. **When those relationships are compromised, the breach is often invisible until the damage has already occurred.**

For Texas, this is not a theoretical risk distributed across a national threat landscape. ERCOT, the Gulf Coast industrial corridor, the Texas Medical Center, the San Antonio defense ecosystem, and the state's rapidly expanding AI and financial infrastructure are specific, identifiable, and documented targets. The convergence of geopolitical pressure and adversary capability this week does not change that reality. It intensifies it.

**Bottom line:** Texas executives should stop asking whether they are in the target set. They are. The more urgent question is whether they would recognize when a trusted relationship has been turned against them — and whether they would know before the decision space to respond has closed.

Section I

## Key Judgments

### KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that North Korea's use of artificial intelligence to conduct social engineering against individuals with privileged access to financial systems and technology infrastructure will **almost certainly** continue to intensify through 2026, and that **Texas financial institutions, fintech operators, and technology companies are inside the operational target profile.** **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

*Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: direct Texas victimization in this cycle is not yet confirmed in open reporting. The targeting logic follows money, access, and opportunity — not geography alone.*

*Decision implication: Decision Implication: Privileged employees need session monitoring and awareness programs that specifically address AI-generated impersonation — not generic phishing training designed for a different threat environment.*

### KJ-2

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that Iran's demonstrated willingness to generate operational disruption against U.S. industrial infrastructure, confirmed in last week's joint federal advisory, **very likely** represents a persistent posture — not a temporary campaign — and that **Texas energy and water operators remain in the highest-risk tier** as long as U.S.-Iran geopolitical confrontation remains unresolved. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

*Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: escalation decisions inside Tehran are driven by political leadership, not technical opportunity alone. The capability is in place. The trigger is geopolitical.*

*Decision implication: Decision Implication: The absence of a Texas-named victim in open reporting this week does not constitute an all-clear. Texas OT operators should maintain elevated posture on internet-reachable industrial systems.*

### KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that PRC Typhoon actors **very likely** retain dormant access inside U.S. critical infrastructure and telecommunications ecosystems, and that the strategic value of that access **increases as U.S.-China competition over Taiwan and technology accelerates** — meaning the risk to Texas is not static; it grows with geopolitical tension. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

*Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: Texas-specific dwell time and access points are not publicly quantified. The national pattern is sufficiently established to justify active threat hunting now.*

*Decision implication: Decision Implication: Communications security and vendor assurance in the Defense Industrial Base are strategic controls. A compromised communication channel defeats cleared personnel practices before a single classified document is involved.*

### KJ-4

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that Operation PowerOFF's disruption of criminal denial-of-service infrastructure will **likely** produce a near-term rebound in disruptive activity — consistent with historical pattern across prior iterations — and that Texas financial services, healthcare portals, and public-facing critical infrastructure operators should treat the next 30 days as a period of elevated availability risk. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

*Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: rebound timing and target selection are not predictable from open sources. Prior PowerOFF phases show reconstitution within two to four weeks, often with elevated activity against high-visibility targets.*

### KJ-5

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE CONFIDENCE** that the federal government's permanent narrowing of its national vulnerability intelligence program **likely** creates a structural intelligence gap for Texas organizations without supplemental threat intelligence sources — increasing the probability that high-impact enterprise software vulnerabilities go unaddressed due to delayed or absent severity guidance. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

*Source basis / uncertainty: Primary uncertainty: impact will not be uniform. Organizations with mature threat intelligence programs will absorb the shift. Smaller operators dependent on national databases as their primary source are more exposed.*

*Decision implication: Decision Implication: Sector ISAC membership, CISA advisory subscriptions, and commercial threat intelligence are no longer optional supplements for Texas organizations in high-risk sectors. They are the baseline.*

## Section II

## What Happened This Week

### North Korea — Artificial Intelligence Is Now a Social Engineering Weapon

**What Happened:** A confirmed North Korean threat actor compromised a technology company this week not by defeating a security system, but by targeting a person. Using AI-enhanced tools to craft contact indistinguishable from legitimate communication, the actor gained access to active login sessions and internal credentials, draining internal accounts before the company detected and contained the intrusion. The financial impact was limited. The method is the warning.

**Why It Matters:** Pyongyang's cyber operations have always been patient and adaptive. What has changed is the quality of deception now available at scale. Artificial intelligence allows North Korean operators to personalize contact in ways that defeat awareness programs designed for generic phishing. Security researchers tracking these campaigns have documented that individuals with privileged system access — developers, IT administrators, finance staff — are now primary targets, not incidental ones, because they are faster and more reliable entry points than defended technical perimeters.

**Geopolitical Context:** North Korea is operating under maximum sanctions pressure. Cyber theft is not a tactical nuisance in Pyongyang's strategic calculus — it is a budget line funding weapons programs and regime survival. The pace of North Korean financial cyber operations in 2026 is tracking above any prior year. That acceleration is a direct consequence of external pressure, not coincidence. The more constrained the regime's economy becomes, the more intensively its cyber forces are directed at financial targets globally.

**Business Risk (Texas Lens):** Texas financial institutions, fintech operators, and technology companies employ the exact workforce profile North Korean actors are targeting — developers with cloud and system access, finance staff with privileged credentials, IT administrators holding the keys to enterprise platforms. The operation does not need to be directed specifically at Texas to land in Texas. It follows the people.

#### ASSESSMENT

AI-enhanced social engineering has materially outpaced most corporate awareness programs. Organizations that have not specifically revised training, session monitoring, and access controls to reflect this threat model are operating on assumptions that no longer describe the adversary they face.

### Iran — Last Week's Warning Has Not Expired

**What Happened:** No new Iran-specific incident emerged in open reporting this week. That is not an all-clear. The joint federal advisory issued last week — from FBI, CISA, NSA, EPA, DOE, and U.S. Cyber Command — confirmed an active Iranian campaign against U.S. industrial control systems already producing operational disruption and financial loss at victim organizations. That campaign did not conclude because a new advisory was not issued.

**Why It Matters:** The absence of a new headline does not change the operational picture. Iranian actors demonstrated in late March and early April that they are willing to move from access to disruption. That willingness is a strategic decision made in Tehran, not a technical capability toggle. The capability has been in place for months. What shifted was the decision to use it — and there is no open-source evidence that decision has been reversed.

**Geopolitical Context:** The February 2026 U.S.-Israel strikes against Iranian targets accelerated a strategic recalculation inside the Iranian regime. Iran's doctrine in response to kinetic pressure has historically included intensified cyber activity against adversary infrastructure — a pattern documented consistently

across the past decade of Iran-U.S. confrontation. The current environment is the most conducive to Iranian cyber escalation since the Soleimani period. That pressure has not eased.

**Business Risk (Texas Lens):** Texas holds more concentrated energy infrastructure per square mile than any other U.S. state. ERCOT's grid isolation, the Gulf Coast LNG export corridor, and the density of petrochemical and water treatment systems in South Texas and the Houston Ship Channel are specific, identifiable, and high-value targets that Iranian actors have documented intent and confirmed capability to affect.

#### ASSESSMENT

Texas OT operators should read last week's federal advisory as a current condition, not a historical document. The campaign it described is assessed as ongoing. The absence of a named Texas victim in open reporting is a disclosure gap, not evidence the threat has passed.

## China — Quiet Access, Growing Consequence

**What Happened:** No new major PRC-attributed incident emerged in open reporting this week. PRC Typhoon operations are not designed to generate weekly headlines. That is, by strategic intent, precisely the point.

**Why It Matters:** China's cyber doctrine inside U.S. critical infrastructure is explicitly preparatory. The ODNI's 2026 Annual Threat Assessment assessed with high confidence that PRC actors have pre-positioned access inside American infrastructure specifically to enable disruption options in a crisis contingency — most plausibly tied to a Taiwan scenario. The access is there. The question is when the geopolitical conditions make activating it worth the cost.

**Geopolitical Context:** U.S.-China competition across trade, technology, and military posture has not abated. Chinese leadership has stated unambiguously that Taiwan reunification is a national priority. Every escalation in that competition increases the strategic value of dormant access inside U.S. infrastructure. China does not need to be in an active conflict to derive leverage from what it already holds inside American networks.

**Business Risk (Texas Lens):** Texas Defense Industrial Base organizations — contractors, suppliers, and technology partners supporting JBSA, Fort Cavazos, and the broader San Antonio defense enterprise — are high-value PRC intelligence targets. Texas telecommunications infrastructure, which underpins executive communications across every sector, remains a documented access layer for PRC actors. An executive whose communications are observable to a foreign intelligence service is a strategic vulnerability, not merely an IT problem.

#### ASSESSMENT

The most consequential PRC cyber outcome for Texas organizations is not a visible disruption. It is the quiet erosion of decision advantage — executives and boards making decisions without knowing their communications and plans are already known to an adversary preparing for a contingency they have not yet fully considered.

## Russia — A Criminal Ecosystem That Serves Strategic Interests

**What Happened:** An international law enforcement coalition executed the latest phase of Operation PowerOFF, seizing 53 criminal platforms used to conduct denial-of-service attacks for hire. Four arrests

were made across 21 participating nations. More than 75,000 identified criminal users received formal warnings that their activity is known. The operation exposed over three million criminal user accounts.

**Why It Matters:** This is significant law enforcement work. It is also, historically, temporary. Criminal cyber infrastructure disrupted by enforcement actions reconstitutes within weeks in most documented prior cases. The Russia-based ransomware and criminal ecosystem that most directly threatens Texas organizations operates at a scale that a single enforcement action does not permanently dismantle. Moscow's tolerance of criminal cyber activity on Russian soil is a strategic policy — not an oversight — and that policy has not changed.

**Geopolitical Context:** Russia's war economy in Ukraine has entered its fifth year. Western sanctions pressure is sustained. The criminal cyber ecosystem operating from Russian territory provides Moscow with disruption capacity against adversaries, strategic ambiguity, and plausible deniability — all at minimal cost. So long as those conditions hold, Russia has no incentive to constrain the infrastructure its territory shelters.

**Business Risk (Texas Lens):** Texas healthcare systems, municipalities, manufacturers, and regional financial institutions remain the consistent target profile for Russia-based ransomware operators. The operational tempo will likely spike in the weeks following PowerOFF as displaced actors reconstitute or retaliate, with Texas public-facing infrastructure a plausible near-term target.

#### ASSESSMENT

Operation PowerOFF disrupted infrastructure. It did not change the geopolitical conditions that make Russian-tolerated cybercrime strategically useful to Moscow. Texas organizations should expect a near-term increase in criminal activity as displaced actors reconstitute.

### Section III

## Texas Sector Implications

#### ■ Energy SEVERE

**Primary risk this week:** Iran's confirmed OT disruption posture remains active; PRC pre-positioning in grid and utility environments continues; criminal ransomware targeting operational continuity through vendor and identity pathways.

**Why Texas is exposed:** ERCOT's grid isolation means Texas cannot import power from neighboring grids during a major disruption event. The Gulf Coast concentration of LNG export terminals, petrochemical plants, and water systems makes Texas the highest-density energy target in the country.

**Executive implication:** Iranian actors have demonstrated willingness to generate real disruption, not just maintain access. That risk does not expire between news cycles. **Killer line:** Texas grid isolation is a resilience feature in normal operations and a compounding factor when coordinated adversary disruption is the scenario.

## ■ Finance HIGH

**Primary risk this week:** North Korean AI-enhanced social engineering targeting individuals with financial system access; criminal ransomware exploiting vendor and third-party trust pathways; near-term DDoS rebound following Operation PowerOFF.

**Why Texas is exposed:** Texas combines major banking institutions with a growing fintech ecosystem and expanding digital-asset adjacent sector — a combination that matches DPRK's documented targeting profile precisely: money, digital access pathways, and a developer workforce with privileged credentials.

**Executive implication:** The threat to Texas financial organizations is not arriving through the technical perimeter. It is arriving through the judgment of individuals your organization trusts. **Killer line:** If your employees hold privileged access to financial systems, they are already inside the adversary's target scope.

♥ Healthcare  
HIGH

**Primary risk this week:** Ransomware actors leveraging vendor concentration and shared access pathways; enterprise software vulnerabilities embedded in clinical data operations; endpoint defense degradation from unpatched systems in regulated environments.

**Why Texas is exposed:** The Texas Medical Center is the largest medical complex in the world. Regional health systems across San Antonio, Dallas, Houston, and Austin operate with a shared vendor ecosystem that creates amplification risk — one compromised supplier can affect multiple institutions simultaneously.

**Executive implication:** In healthcare, cyber disruption is not an IT problem. It is a patient safety and regulatory problem with a clock attached. **Killer line:** A Texas hospital's cyber risk no longer stops at its own network boundary — it extends to every vendor, platform, and integration that touches patient data or clinical operations.

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| <p>■ Defense / DIB<br/>HIGH</p>             | <p><b>Primary risk this week:</b> PRC espionage through enterprise communication platforms and telecom access layers; North Korean workforce infiltration through AI-assisted impersonation targeting cleared personnel; enterprise access platform vulnerabilities exploitable in contractor network environments.</p> <p><b>Why Texas is exposed:</b> JBSA hosts the densest concentration of military cyber and intelligence units in the country. Port San Antonio and the surrounding DIB ecosystem employ thousands of cleared contractors whose communications and credentials are high-value targets for both Chinese espionage and North Korean infiltration campaigns.</p> <p><b>Executive implication:</b> Communications security is a strategic control, not a compliance checkbox. <b>Killer line:</b> The adversary does not need to breach your classified systems if they can read the business discussions that precede classification decisions.</p>                                                                                                                           |
| <p>■ AI / Data<br/>Centers<br/>ELEVATED</p> | <p><b>Primary risk this week:</b> Developer and engineering workforce targeted by AI-enhanced social engineering; enterprise integration software under active exploitation in AI data pipeline environments; federal vulnerability intelligence narrowing creating patch prioritization gaps for rapidly evolving AI infrastructure stacks.</p> <p><b>Why Texas is exposed:</b> Texas is adding AI and data center infrastructure faster than almost any other state. The engineers managing that buildout hold privileged access to cloud environments and large-scale data systems — the exact workforce profile North Korean operators are now specifically pursuing.</p> <p><b>Executive implication:</b> AI infrastructure is only as secure as the people who access it and the intelligence your team has about the threats targeting them. <b>Killer line:</b> The most consequential cyber risk to Texas AI infrastructure this week is not a novel exploit — it is a person with the wrong message in their inbox and no training that addresses what that message now looks like.</p> |

## Section IV

### Priority Intelligence Requirements (PIRs)

#### PIR-1 Does the Iranian OT disruption campaign confirmed last week extend to Texas-specific targets? [**↑ RISING**]

- CISA, FBI, or Texas DIR reporting that names Texas-specific sectors or operators in connection with the Iranian ICS campaign
- Anomalous activity in industrial control environments — unexplained configuration changes, access events, or display manipulation
- Utility, water, or petrochemical disruption in Texas with unclear or unattributed technical origin

→ Iranian leadership statements or U.S.-Iran developments that would change escalation calculus in Tehran

The joint federal advisory described an ongoing campaign producing real operational disruption.

Texas-specific victim identification has not emerged in public reporting. That is a disclosure gap, not evidence the campaign is absent from Texas. The operating assumption for Texas energy and water operators should be: within scope until confirmed otherwise.

### **PIR-2 Are Texas financial and technology organizations adapting human-layer defenses to match North Korea's AI-enhanced social engineering threat? [[↑ RISING](#)]**

→ Unusual or high-pressure outreach to employees with privileged system access, particularly from new or unverified contacts

→ Anomalous session activity — logins from unexpected locations, devices, or outside normal hours for privileged accounts

→ New contractor or vendor onboarding with unusually rapid access grants to sensitive systems

→ Developer community reports of suspicious recruitment contacts that include technical assessments requiring code execution

DPRK actors successfully used AI-enhanced tools to compromise a technology firm employee this week. The attack surface is not the network — it is the person. Most corporate awareness programs were not designed for this threat model. The gap is real and actively being exploited.

### **PIR-3 Are Texas organizations completing required remediation on this week's critical enterprise access platform disclosures before adversaries weaponize them? [[↑ RISING](#)]**

→ Confirmation from IT leadership that manual steps — beyond automated patches — have been completed

→ Authentication anomalies in collaboration platform logs suggesting unexpected session activity

→ Unusual lateral movement in network segments managed by access control systems

→ InfraGard or sector ISAC reporting of active exploitation against these platforms in peer organizations

This week's Cisco disclosures in enterprise collaboration and network access platforms require manual administrator action — not only vendor-side patching. Large enterprise environments historically lag weeks behind critical disclosures when remediation requires active configuration changes. The exploitation window is already open.

### **PIR-4 Do Texas organizations in high-risk sectors have independent threat intelligence sources now that federal vulnerability enrichment support has permanently narrowed? [[→ EMERGING](#)]**

→ Current patch prioritization process — does it depend solely on federal enrichment or national severity scores?

→ Active CISA advisory subscriptions and sector ISAC membership status

→ InfraGard San Antonio participation and direct engagement with sector information sharing

→ Internal capacity to evaluate vendor advisories independently when national enrichment is absent

NIST's reduction in national vulnerability database enrichment is structural and permanent, driven by a volume increase that has outpaced federal capacity. Organizations without supplemental sources will not receive timely severity guidance for most newly disclosed enterprise software vulnerabilities.

## **Section V**

### **Indicators to Watch — Next 2–4 Weeks**

**01 Texas-named victims or operators** appearing in federal or state reporting connected to the Iranian industrial control system campaign confirmed last week.

**02 Iran-U.S. geopolitical developments** — diplomatic signals, military posture changes, or Iranian leadership statements — that would increase likelihood of intensified cyber activity against U.S. energy infrastructure.

**03 Additional DPRK social engineering incidents** targeting Texas fintech, financial, or technology developer communities — the AI-enabled method confirmed this week will be replicated at scale.

**04 DDoS rebound activity** targeting Texas financial services portals, healthcare systems, or public-facing critical infrastructure following Operation PowerOFF.

**05 Active exploitation of enterprise access platform vulnerabilities** in Texas organizations — particularly healthcare, DIB, and financial services where these platforms are most densely deployed.

**06 Ransomware claims naming Texas hospitals, municipalities, or manufacturers** with shared vendor or third-party access origin — the supply-chain amplification pattern from Q1 2026 continues.

**07 PRC-linked reporting on telecom or communications compromise** affecting Texas-based cleared contractors or executives in the defense ecosystem around JBSA and Fort Cavazos.

**08 Taiwan Strait developments** — Chinese military exercises, diplomatic escalation, or U.S. policy responses — that would increase probability of PRC cyber activation in pre-positioned U.S. infrastructure access.

Section VI

## Executive Implications & Recommended Actions

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### 1 — Treat Your People as Part of Your Security Perimeter

North Korea confirmed this week that it can make a fraudulent contact indistinguishable from a legitimate one. If employees hold privileged access to financial systems, cloud infrastructure, or sensitive data, your awareness program needs to specifically address AI-generated impersonation. Session monitoring for privileged accounts and additional scrutiny for new vendor relationships are not optional. **What happens if you get this wrong:** the adversary enters through your most trusted employee — invisibly — and the damage is done before your security team sees an alert.

### 2 — Maintain Elevated Posture on Iranian OT Risk

Last week's federal advisory confirmed an active Iranian campaign producing real operational disruption. No new Texas incident in open reporting this week does not mean the threat has passed. Texas energy and water operators should maintain elevated vigilance on industrial systems reachable from external networks. **What happens if you get this wrong:** when disruption arrives, leadership responds from a standing start rather than from an elevated posture that could have shortened detection and decision time.

### 3 — Confirm Enterprise Platform Remediation Is Actually Complete

This week's critical disclosures in enterprise collaboration and network access platforms required manual administrator actions — beyond vendor-side patches. Ask your IT leadership directly whether those steps have been taken and whether anomalous authentication is being monitored. **What happens if you get this wrong:** an adversary with no privileged access can impersonate any user in your collaboration environment or achieve code execution on your network controller, with no visible indicator until a downstream event forces it into the open.

### 4 — Build an Independent Intelligence Layer Before You Need It

The federal government has permanently narrowed its vulnerability intelligence support. Organizations still treating national databases as their primary patch prioritization input are now operating with structural gaps. Sector ISAC membership, CISA advisory subscriptions, and commercial threat intelligence are not premium additions — they are the baseline for the current environment. **What happens if you get this wrong:** a high-impact vulnerability sits unaddressed in your environment because it never received a federal severity score, and you learn about it through an incident rather than a warning.

## Section VII

## Analyst's Note

### ANALYST'S NOTE

What strikes me most this week is how clearly technology is following geopolitics. Iran did not escalate against U.S. industrial systems because a particular technical opportunity emerged. It escalated because the political decision was made in Tehran, after February's strikes, that raising the cost of confrontation was strategically necessary. North Korea is not targeting financial systems because the opportunity arose this week. It is targeting them because regime survival requires the revenue that cyber theft provides, and that requirement intensifies as external pressure grows. China is not maintaining access inside American infrastructure because it is technically interesting. It is maintaining it because contingency planning for a potential Taiwan scenario requires it.

These are durable strategic conditions. They do not resolve between news cycles. Every executive reading this brief is operating an organization that exists inside the target logic of at least one of them — and in Texas, more likely two or three simultaneously.

The practical question this week is the same one it was last week: **if a trusted relationship — a person, a platform, an industrial system, a communication channel — was turned against you today, how long before you would know?** For most organizations, the honest answer is measured in days or weeks. Closing that gap is not a security project. It is a business resilience decision that belongs at the board level, informed by an understanding of the geopolitical conditions that are making it urgent.

## Section VIII — Sourcing

## Source Notes

### OPEN SOURCE BASIS — ATB-2026-6 — UPDATED FOR THE WEEK OF 19 APRIL 2026

#### Cisco and enterprise platform vulnerability reporting

[Article](#)

#### CISA Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog

[CISA KEV catalog](#)

#### NIST National Vulnerability Database operations update

[NIST update](#)

#### Zerion and DPRK AI-enabled social engineering reporting

[Incident reporting](#)

#### Operation PowerOFF law-enforcement reporting

[Article](#)

#### Huntress / Microsoft Defender zero-day reporting

[Article](#)

#### Iranian PLC exploitation advisory

[EPA advisory release](#)

#### ODNI and CrowdStrike threat baselines

[ODNI reports](#)

**TORCH FUSION CYCLE**

**WHAT:** North Korea weaponized AI against people rather than systems; Iran's OT disruption posture from last week remains active without evidence of retreat; China holds pre-positioned access growing more consequential as Taiwan-related tension persists; Russia's tolerated criminal ecosystem disrupted by law enforcement but assessed to reconstitute within weeks; federal vulnerability intelligence support permanently narrowed. **WHO:** DPRK Lazarus ecosystem, Iranian state-directed cyber units, PRC Typhoon clusters, Russia-based ransomware operators, displaced criminal DDoS actors. **WHY:** Geopolitical pressure — Iranian confrontation with the U.S., North Korean sanctions, Chinese Taiwan contingency planning, Russian wartime interests — is driving every major adversary behavior pattern threatening Texas organizations this week. **WHAT NEXT:** Texas organizations should plan for sustained multi-actor pressure through Q2 and Q3 2026, with highest-probability near-term impact arriving through human-layer targeting, trusted access compromise, and vendor-path ransomware rather than headline infrastructure attacks.

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